

Family Campephagidae

Cuckooshrikes

Length 5½–16 in (14–40 cm)

Species 92



Cuckooshrikes have no connection with either cuckoos or shrikes. This is mainly a tropical family consisting of 2 groups of birds ranging from Africa across southern and Southeast Asia to Australia and the islands in the western Pacific; the minivets occur only in Asia. Except for the ground cuckoo-shrike, found on the treeless Australian plains, these are usually tree-living birds. Minivets are colorful

birds, the size of wagtails; the male tends to be red and black, whereas the female is yellow or orange and black or gray. The remaining cuckooshrikes resemble cuckoos in flight and are often dull gray, ranging from the size of sparrows to that of pigeons. The females of the latter group are often paler, and many species have bristles growing from the base of the bill. The nest is built high in a tree and the female lays 2–5 eggs, usually incubating them alone.



COMMON CICADABIRD

Found in Australia, Papua New Guinea, and eastern Indonesia, *Coracina tenuirostris* lives in the canopy of rain forest and other woodland. The female is browner with barred underparts. The name is derived from the male's harsh, descending, cicada-like buzz, which it repeats often. This bird is 9½–10 in (24–26 cm) long.

GRAY-CHINNED MINIVET

Found from the Himalayas through southern China and Southeast Asia to Borneo, *Pericrocotus solaris* lives in open forest. It measures 7½ in (19 cm) in length. The male has a gray throat and an orange belly, but the female is duller with yellow rather than orange underparts.

Family Neosittidae

Sittellas

Length 10–14 cm (4–5 in)

Species 3



Found in Australia and New Guinea, sittellas superficially resemble northern nuthatches, with wedge-shaped heads and bills, short tails, and strong feet.

They also move around tree branches in much the same way, with a series of short hops.



VARIED SITTELLA

Small groups of *Daphoenositta chrysoptera* forage in gum trees and acacias, taking insects, beetle larvae, and spiders from loose bark and crevices, often working downward through a tree. Their head patterns vary across the range; in flight, a bold white rump and orange wingbars catch the eye.

These birds rely on their strong toes for climbing, not using their tails for support. Social birds, they often preen one another and roost in tight groups side by side on a branch, the older males taking the outermost positions. They eat insects and spiders, especially beetle larvae, taken from bark with the bill and then held down with the feet to be broken up and eaten. Nests are typically high in eucalyptus trees, built in a tight fork and well camouflaged with strips of bark. The incubating female is fed both by the male and associated "helpers" and a group may assist in raising broods from two nests at once.

Family Platysteiridae

Wattle-eyes and batises

Length 3¼–6½ in (8–16 cm)

Species 33



All of these birds are found in Africa, mostly in forest or forest edges. Wattle-eyes have colorful wattles around their eyes. Batises are small, flycatcher-like birds. Males generally have contrasting black and white plumage—often with a breastband; females are brownish below. They are insectivorous and can catch their prey on the wing. They build cup-shaped nests and lay 2–5 eggs. Various species of wattle-eyes and batises look very similar and are easily

confused. However, they can usually be separated on the basis of geographical distribution.



CHINSPOT BATIS

Found in Sudan, Kenya, southwest Africa, and Mozambique, *Batis molitor* frequents open woodland, darting out after insects like a flycatcher; it also hovers to search leaves. It is 4 in (10 cm) long, and has a gray crown.

Family Pachycephalidae

Whistlers

Length 4¾–11 in (12–28 cm)

Species 57



The whistlers make up an Indo-Pacific family of birds, ranging from Indochina to the southwest Pacific. As their name suggests, they are known for their impressively strong calls and songs. They reach their maximum diversity in rain forests on mountains of New Guinea and on tropical islands around the region, where they have evolved into many local species and subspecies—most in the genus *Pachycephalus*. Whistlers are big-headed birds

(*Pachycephalus* means "thick-head") and females are usually drabber than males. Plumage varies from plain to colorful plumage: males of many have a blackbreast band so making species identification difficult. They feed on insects, which they glean from foliage—larger species take small vertebrate prey, too. They forage in the mid- to upper levels in forests, and at least one species is a specialist inhabitant of mangrove swamps. Others occur in drier eucalyptus woodland. Information on breeding is limited, but both sexes usually incubate the eggs. Recent evidence suggests that some big-beaked birds from other families—such as shrike-tits (below) and shrike-thrushes—may be closely related to whistlers and should perhaps be placed in the family Pachycephalidae.



AUSTRALIAN GOLDEN WHISTLER

Found in Indonesia, southern and eastern Australia, Tasmania, and Fiji, *Pachycephala pectoralis* shows wide geographical variation: about 73 subspecies have been described. It is 6½–7 in (16–18 cm) long; the gray-brown female lacks the male's black and white and much of the yellow coloring. It may be found in mixed-species flocks.

CRESTED SHRIKE TIT

Falcunculus frontatus is found in various parts of Australia, in habitats ranging from rain forests to gardens. It uses its strong bill to tear off loose bark in its search for insects. About 6–7½ in (15–19 cm) long, it has a black crest. The female's throat is olive, the male's is black.

